Budgeting apps punish you on the weeks you need them *most.*

A UX and visual design case study for a money app built on steadiness, not restriction.



72%

of U.S. adults said they feel stressed about money at least some of the time.

So the person opening a finance app is already a little anxious. That’s the default user, not the edge case.

American Psychological Association, *Stress in America: Paying With Our Health* (2015). Survey of 3,068 adults, August 2014.

When the news is bad, we look *away.*

Researchers call it the ostrich effect: investors checked their portfolios more often in rising markets than in falling ones.

An app that greets a rough week with red numbers is teaching people to stop opening it.

Karlsson, Loewenstein & Seppi, *The ostrich effect* (2009); Sicherman, Loewenstein, Seppi & Utkus, *Financial Attention* (2016).

Not ~~What did you spend?~~

But **How long are you covered?**

You’re steady through

Oct 25

9 days past your next payday. Bills before then are already set aside.

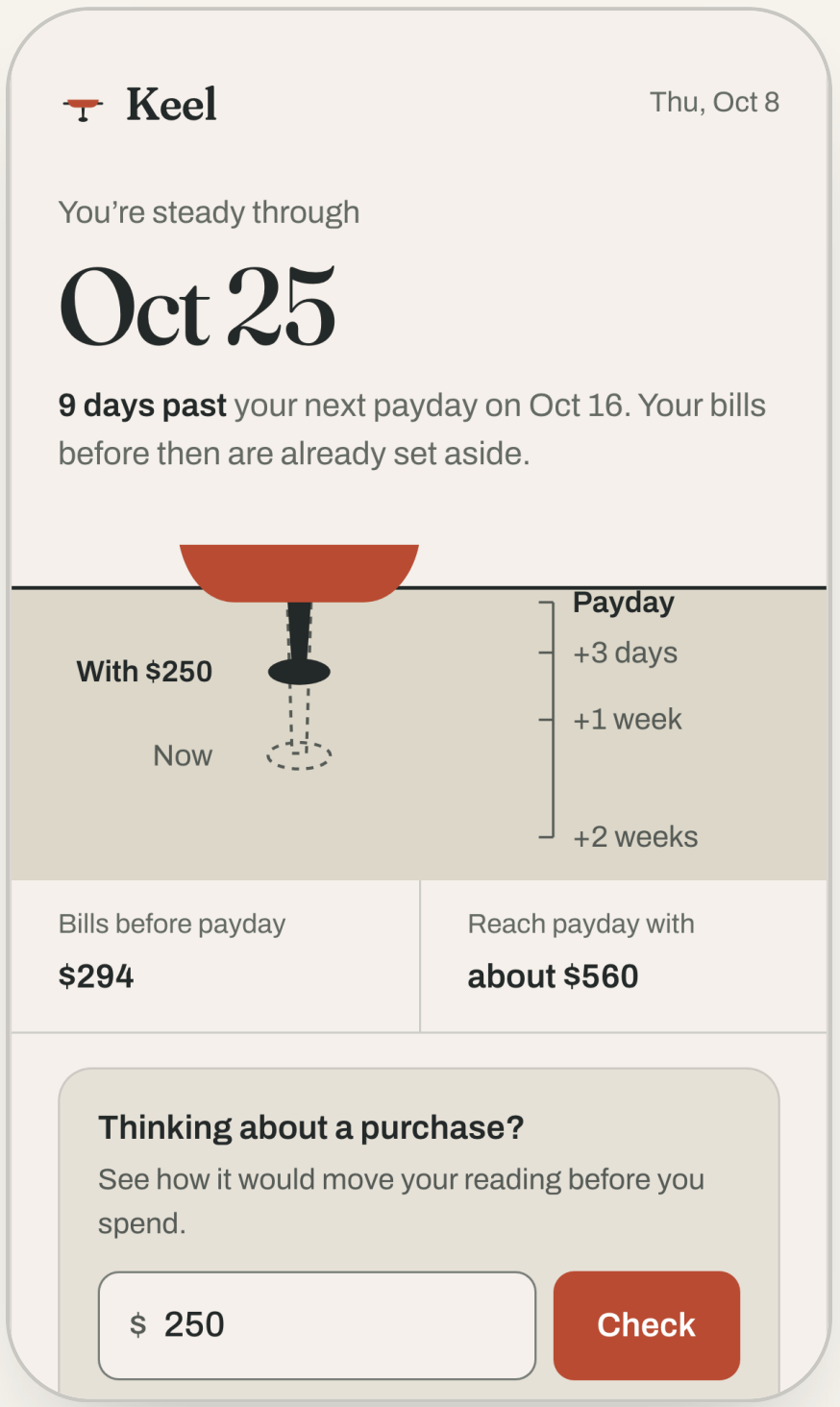
The headline is a date, not a balance: walk forward from today, subtract usual spending and bills, ignore future income.

One picture, one *meaning.*

The waterline is payday.
Always, on every screen.

The keel's depth is room.
How many days past payday your money lasts.

Check before you buy.
A $250 purchase shortens the keel to 4 days; the dashed outline shows where it was.

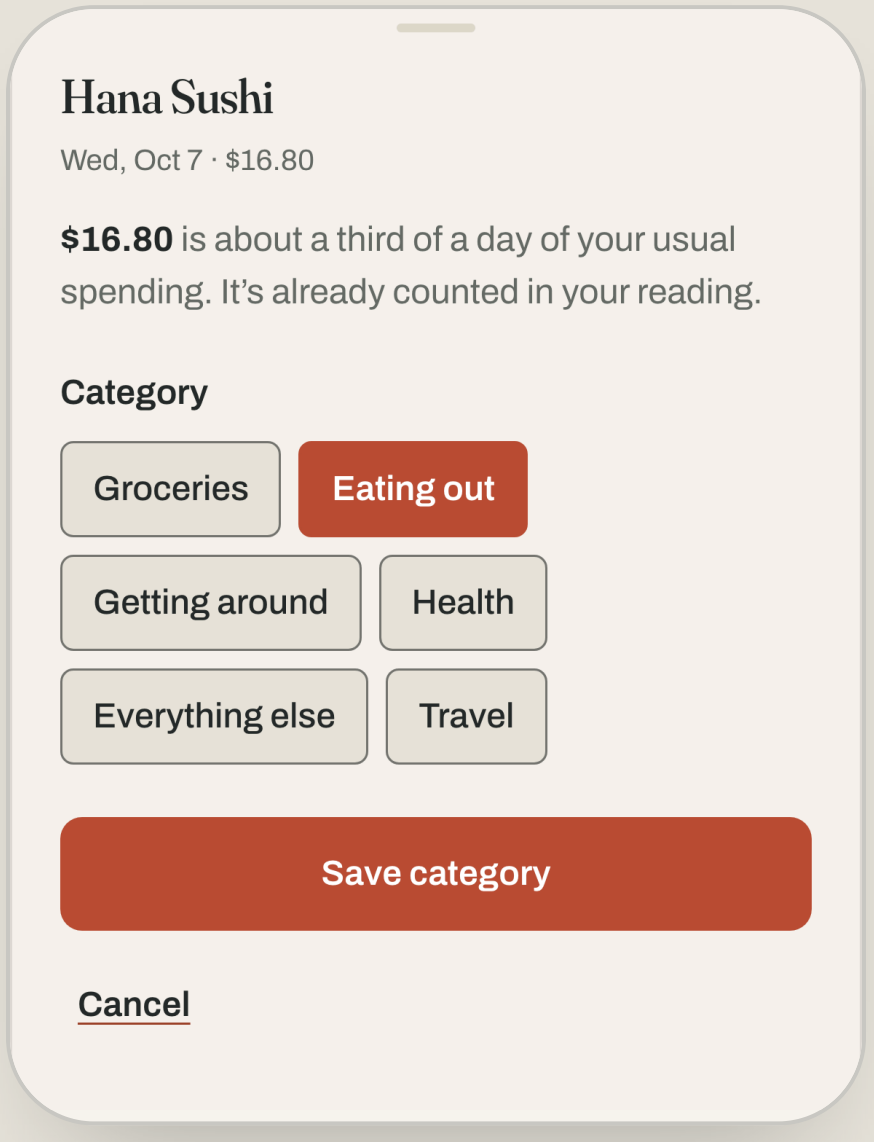


Weight, not *walls.*

Spending doesn’t break limits. It shifts weight.

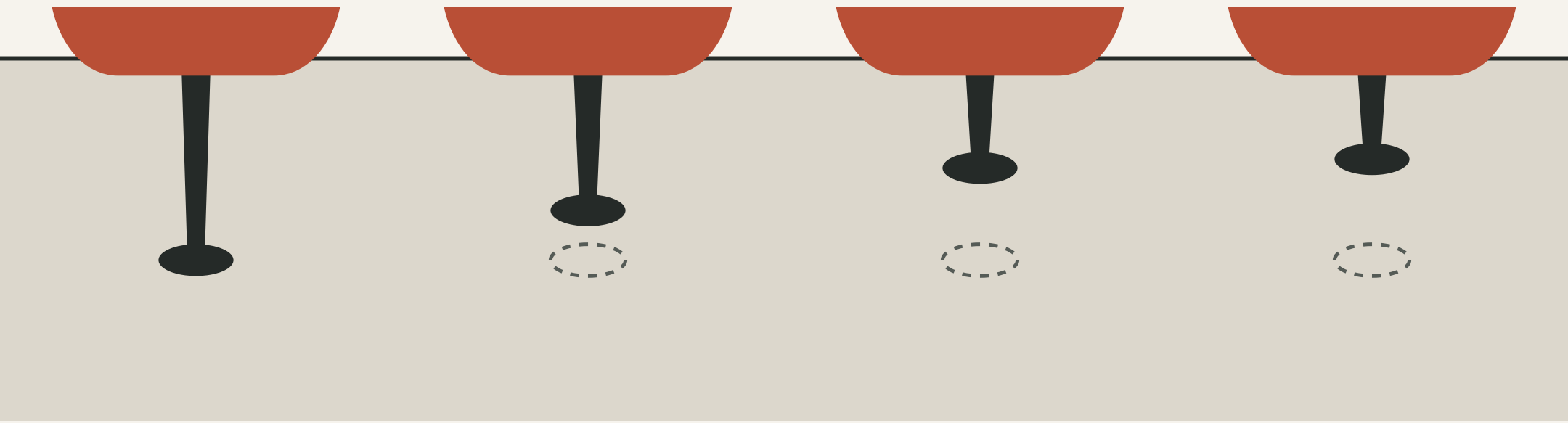
No red overages.
No category ceilings that “break”.

Cost in days, not guilt.
$16.80 of sushi is about a third of a day of usual spending, already counted.



Settle, don’t *startle.*

When your reading changes, the keel eases to its new depth like a boat taking on weight, then stops. About 900ms, no bounce.



~~shakes~~ ~~red flashes~~ ~~confetti~~ ~~badge counts~~

---

12 Lottie animations and 4 Rive state machines, all written in code, each with a dark version and a reduced-motion state.

Calm still has to be *checked.*

0

contrast failures across 713 text measurements in 16 app states, light and dark

61fps

through the hero animation with the CPU slowed 4×

320px

narrowest screen tested with no sideways scrolling; keyboard focus stays inside every dialog

Not tested with people yet. The research is a literature and competitor review, and the five-second and task tests are planned, not run. The case study says so.

Read the case study. Then try the *prototype.*

Research, IA, wireframes, identity, motion system and a working app with real calculations. **Links in the comments.**

Should a money app ever show you red?

Shyine Makin · UX and visual design · Keel is a fictional concept.